



BE USEFUL

Seven Tools for Life

Arnold Schwarzenegger



The Big “So What”

This book reveals 7 critical tools to overcome challenges, stay motivated, and create a life of purpose and fulfillment. The insights are based on Arnold Schwarzenegger’s personal experiences in bodybuilding, acting, politics, and public service; they’re relevant whether you’re at a low point in life or seeking new success.



Introduction



In this book, Arnold Schwarzenegger—politician, businessman, bodybuilder, and actor—shares his personal insights on **purpose, resilience, and growth**.

- After leaving the Governor’s office in 2011, Arnold encountered multiple personal crises, including family issues and career challenges. Despite hitting rock bottom, he was determined to rebuild his life.
- As he worked through these challenges, recovered and transformed himself, Arnold was surprised to find others turning to him for motivation and inspiration. He realized that, despite the progress in human civilization—with less war, disease, and poverty—we’re now grappling with a social epidemic of negativity, with a sharp rise in depression, anxiety, and addiction worldwide.



Arnold wrote this book to share his **“tool kit for life”**—a set of principles developed over 60 years of personal experience. These tools can help you to bounce back from adversity, and serve as a blueprint for living a happy, successful, and meaningful life.

KEY QUOTES

“I wrote this book because I believe that anyone can benefit from the tools I’ve used through every phase of my life... But most of all, I wrote it because everybody needs to be useful.”

“It’s the struggle that makes success, when you achieve it, taste so sweet.”

“There has never been less war, less disease, less poverty, less oppression than right now...[but] so many people talk about feeling irrelevant or invisible or hopeless.”

“I was face down in the mud, in a dark hole, and I had to decide whether it was worth it to clean myself up and start the slow climb out, or to just give up.”



The 7 Tools for Life



1. VISION: Define Your Path with a Clear Vision



Having a clear vision means having a clear mental picture of what you want your life to look like, as well as what you don't want.

- It provides purpose and meaning, serving as a compass for decision-making and helping you to stay on-track toward your goals.
 - (i) It helps you to make better choices by assessing which option can bring you closer to your desired future.
 - (ii) It provides a sense of direction to reduce doubt and confusion.
- Without a clear vision, people often feel lost or adrift, finding it hard to take meaningful actions. They might feel like life is happening to them without control, or get stuck in jobs or routines that don't fulfill them.



Success comes from a crystal-clear, vivid vision, not just vague hopes.

- A vision reminds you on what true success is and isn't for you, helping you to prioritize long-term success over short-term gains. Once you're clear on what you truly want, you can calmly accept or reject opportunities, avoiding

KEY QUOTES

"No man is more unhappy than he who never faces adversity. For he is not permitted to prove himself."
—Seneca

"To have a clear vision is to have a picture of what you want your life to look like and a plan for how to get there. The people who feel most lost have neither of those."

"We always have a choice. What we don't always have, unless we create it, is something to measure our choices against."

"You need to get crystal clear on that vision and tattoo it to the inside of your eyelids."

distractions and “near-successes” that don’t fully align with your goals. For example, in 1974, Arnold turned down a \$200,000-a-year offer to be a fitness promoter because it didn’t fit with his goal of breaking into Hollywood.

- Visualize and mentally rehearse every detail of your success. During Arnold’s bodybuilding days, he imagined the exact moment of standing on the winner’s podium and even the colors of his competitors’ outfits.



It’s not enough to just visualize your future. You must also **reflect honestly** if the person you see in the mirror aligns with who you want to become.

- Use regular self-reflection to ensure your actions match your vision. This is uncomfortable but necessary for growth.



There are 2 ways to **build a vision from scratch**.

- Start small then build it out: Focus on immediate, tangible goals and develop clarity over time.
 - (i) Start with simple daily tasks you enjoy—like organizing your workspace or exercising—to create small wins.
 - (ii) As you accumulate victories and build momentum, your vision will also expand and sharpen.
- Start broad then zoom in: Use your passions or obsessions as a rough guide, then refine your vision progressively.
 - (i) For example, Arnold’s vision began with “I want to be successful in America.” It became clearer and more specific over time as he pursued bodybuilding, then acting, and politics.
 - (ii) Many successful people, like Steven Spielberg (film) or Tiger Woods (golf), began with broad interests that later evolved into specific goals.
- Either way, it takes time to define and crystalize your vision. Here are a few steps you can use to get started:
 - (i) Reflect on your childhood dreams or early obsessions for clues.

KEY QUOTES

“Knowing what is and isn’t success brings crystal clarity to your vision. And with that clarity...comes a sense of calm, because almost every question becomes easier to answer.”

“You have to check in with yourself if you want to be sure that you’re moving in the right direction... You need to know whether or not your vision aligns with the reality of your choices.”

“As important as it is to know what success looks like, it’s equally important to know what it doesn’t look like.”

“Everything good, all great change, starts with a clear vision.”

- (ii) Set daily or weekly goals to explore those areas, using small wins to build a larger sense of purpose.
- (iii) Create time and space for self-reflection, e.g. walking, exercising, or meditating to clear your mind and refine your vision.



2. AMBITION: Think Big, Act Relentlessly



Small thinking leads to small outcomes. To achieve greatness and fulfill your true potential, you must **think big** from the start.

- Don't assume you've "arrived" just because you've achieved one goal. Keep expanding your vision and pushing boundaries.
- For example, after conquering the world of bodybuilding, Arnold set his sights on the film industry. His first breaks came from action films like *Conan the Barbarian* and *The Terminator*. But he didn't stop there—he expanded into comedy, a genre many thought a muscle-bound action star couldn't succeed in, with hits like *Twins* and *Kindergarten Cop*.



Once you've committed to a goal, give it 100% and **do it right**. When Arnold took on bodybuilding, he aimed to be the best in the world, leading him to win Mr. Olympia multiple times. When he took on role of the Terminator, he trained rigorously to embody the machine-like precision that made the character so iconic.

- To truly stand out, aim to set new records and do what no one else has done before.
 - (i) In bodybuilding, Arnold became the youngest Mr. Olympia at age 23 and won the title 7 times in total.
 - (ii) In film, his movie *Terminator 2: Judgment Day* became the highest-grossing film of 1991, setting a new standard for action films and earning over \$500 million globally.
 - (iii) In politics, Arnold made history in 2003 by becoming the first bodybuilder and actor to be elected Governor of California during the state's unprecedented recall election.



As you pursue big goals you will inevitably encounter **naysayers**.

KEY QUOTES

"If you aim for a big goal and give it your all and you come up short, that's OK because you've still probably done something pretty impressive."

"If you're going to do it, do it... because not going all in will absolutely guarantee that you fall short."

"It's no harder to think big than it is to think small. The only hard part is giving yourself permission to think that way."

"Naysayers are a fact of life. That doesn't mean they get to have a say in your life."

KEY QUOTES

- You can either ignore them or use their negativity as a source of motivation (to prove them wrong). But never believe them.
- Take Steven Spielberg for example. He was rejected from film school but went on to become one of the greatest filmmakers. Likewise, Oprah Winfrey was told early in her career that she wasn't fit for television, yet she became a media icon.



Commit fully to your vision by rejecting backup plans. Having a Plan B will only dilute your focus and determination. For example, once Arnold decided to pursue acting, he rejected other career options and offers to stay focused on succeeding in Hollywood.



3. WORK ETHIC: Unlock Success Through Hard Work



Consistent, focused hard work is non-negotiable for long-term success and fulfillment.

- Hard work can be satisfying in itself, but the real purpose is to build the foundation so you're prepared to seize opportunities, rise to challenges, and excel in critical moments.
- You tend to appreciate an achievement much more when you've earned it. Those who take shortcuts or receive windfalls miss out on the sense of pride and accomplishment that comes from genuine effort—like the difference between climbing Mount Everest yourself versus being dropped at the top by helicopter.



To excel in any field, you need hours of repeated practice.

- Whether you're preparing for a speech, training for a competition, or mastering a craft, the key is to do the reps, and to do them right.
- Every top performer—from athletes to scientists—devotes time to building their skills, abilities, and confidence, so they can perform at their best when the critical moment arrives.



To achieve breakthroughs, you must embrace discomfort.

- Accept pain as a part of growth. In physical training, the last

"I don't compromise. There is no plan B. Plan B is to succeed at plan A."

"If there is one unavoidable truth in this world, it's that there is no substitute for putting in the work."

"The purpose of all this hard work...is to be prepared. It's to be ready to perform when the spotlight turns on, when opportunity knocks, when the cameras roll, when a crisis arrives."

"Working your ass off is the only thing that works 100 percent of the time for 100 percent of the things worth achieving."

"Work works....No matter what you do. No matter who you are."

"Pain isn't just an indicator of sacrifice...it's also a measure of growth potential."

few reps (when pain and fatigue set in) are the ones that drive the most progress. The same applies to personal and professional growth—if you're not feeling discomfort, then you're not pushing yourself to your full potential.

- Remember: pain is temporary, but the satisfaction and results of pushing through it lasts far longer.



Even with the best plans and effort, unexpected challenges can still arise. That's why it's crucial to stay dedicated and **deliver on your commitments**.

- Consistency is key to make sure your ideas and efforts succeed. Show up and follow through, even when it's difficult. During Arnold's political career, he made it a point to personally check in on the progress of his projects to ensure things are on track and his team kept the promises made to the public. It often requires examining details that would otherwise have been overlooked.
- Make room for your goals. Everyone has 24 hours a day, so time is no excuse. Remove distractions and carve out time for your most important goals.
 - Do a *mental accounting* of how you spend your 24 hours. Besides time for sleep, commuting, work, and family, how are you using your time each day? What unproductive hours can you direct toward your goals? Even if you free up just 1 hour a day for your goals, that adds up to 365 hours in a year—more than enough to make significant progress!
 - When you focus on meaningful work and push your limits, you're also more likely to enter a *flow state*, where you perform at your highest level to deliver extraordinary results.



4. INFLUENCE: Sell Your Vision with Impact



To achieve your goals and dreams, you must **sell your vision**. No matter how great your idea is, it doesn't truly exist if nobody knows about it.

- Selling means effectively communicating your vision so

KEY QUOTES

"To do great things that last, sacrifices are necessary."

"If you want to grow, or you want to be great, it's not going to be easy. It's going to hurt a little bit. Or a lot."

"It's about leaving no stone unturned. It's about dotting your i's and crossing your t's. It's about closing the loop and circling back."

"Don't be a lazy fuck. Do the work. The only time you are allowed to use the phrase 'I took care of it' is when it is done. Completely."

"What every person who gets shit done has in common is that they either find the time, make the time, or turn the time they do have into what it needs to be for them to accomplish the task in front of them."

"You can have the most amazing idea, the most fantastic plan, the best in class of virtually anything, but if nobody knows that it exists or knows what it is, then it's a waste of time and effort."

others understand its value. You need persuasive skills, whether you're pitching an idea, seeking support, or presenting yourself for a role.

 To sell successfully, you must know your audience or "customers." These could be anyone whose support or backing you need, such as family members, colleagues, or investors.

- Tailor your approach based on a deep understanding of your audience's needs. For example, when transitioning to comedies, Arnold had to sell his vision to agents, producers, and studio executives who doubted his potential. He was also constantly selling his movies and himself to journalists and critics to secure favorable reviews.

 Share your goals and vision with conviction and sincerity.

- Before you can persuade others, you must first convince yourself. When you believe in your own success, it's easier to bring others along. For example, Joe Weider marketed bodybuilding as if it were already a mainstream sport, even before it truly was.
- Talk about your goals as if they're already happening, using present-tense language to project confidence. For example, say "It is happening" or "I can see myself succeeding" rather than "I hope..." or "I will be..."
- Let others underestimate you, and then exceed their expectations. Arnold used this approach in the 2003 recall election. By surpassing expectations, he left a lasting impression.
- The most effective way to sell is with authenticity. People respond to genuine stories. When you share your personal journey or goals honestly and sincerely, you are more likely to earn trust and support. This works whether you're trying to get a promotion or persuade someone to back your project.

5. RESILIENCE: Shift Gears and Bounce Back

 When pursuing ambitious goals, you will inevitably face challenges and failures. It's crucial to "shift gears" by quickly

KEY QUOTES

"Unless you pay attention to who is paying attention to you, it's impossible to know for sure who your vision is attracting positively or who it might be impacting negatively."

"No matter the size of your dream, you have to know how to sell it and who to sell it to...because no one is better equipped or motivated than you to sell your vision to the world."

"Nothing sells better than a true story from a genuine person. Especially when the story is about that person."

"If you can choose joy over jealousy, happiness over hate, love over resentment, positivity over negativity, then you have the tools to make the best of any situation, even one that feels like failure."

adjusting your mindset and approach, instead of dwelling on negativity, blame, or complaints.

- Human beings have a natural "negative bias" that leads us to focus on potential problems. It's a survival instinct to help us avoid danger, but it can also cause us to fixate on setbacks.
- To shift gears, catch any negative thoughts and actively redirect your focus toward lessons, opportunities, and solutions. This helps you to turn difficult situations into something productive.
- Arnold has a no-complaint rule: Instead of wasting mental energy on complaints, use that energy to solve problems instead. If you're not willing to take action, then the issue can't be really important to you.
 - For example, just before the filming of *Terminator: Dark Fate*, Arnold had to undergo an emergency heart surgery. Rather than blame others or allow this to derail him, he worked closely with his medical team to recover quickly within 3 months, and managed to start production on schedule.



How you respond to failure determines whether you grow or stagnate. Reframe failure as a stepping stone toward success.

- Failure is a natural part of the journey toward success. See it as a source of feedback to learn what doesn't work, so you can move closer to success.
- When facing setbacks, remember Arnold's iconic line from *The Terminator*: "I'll be back." Choose to bounce back stronger, and never give up.



To stand out and achieve greatness, you can't blindly follow what others are doing. Sometimes, you must break away from convention.

- For instance, Arnold redefined bodybuilding by focusing on a more sculpted and aesthetic physique rather than sheer size. In movies, he refused to stick to a single lane, successfully transitioning from action roles to comedies. In politics, he defied expectations by winning California's 2003 recall election as an outsider candidate.
- Remember: Risk is manageable, not something to be feared.

KEY QUOTES

"You work to make a dream come true, you don't whine it into existence."

"Your job is neither to avoid failure nor to seek it out. Your job is to bust your ass in pursuit of your vision...and to embrace the failure that is bound to come."

"Failure has never killed a dream; quitting kills every dream it touches."

"My entire life has been an exercise in doing things differently than they've always been done."

- Consider what you stand to lose versus what you can gain. Early in his career, Arnold had little to lose, which gave him a high tolerance for risk. As he became more successful, he learned how to *minimize the downsides* while still taking bold steps.
- Ask yourself, “*What do I have to lose?*” If you’ve prepared and worked hard, then failure becomes just another learning opportunity. Even when things don’t go as planned, just switch gears and keep moving forward.



6. GROWTH MINDSET: Stay Open and Keep Learning

 A learning mindset beats paper qualifications any day. When you see the world as your classroom, you can find endless opportunities for learning and growth.

- There’s no one-size-fits-all route to success, and you don’t need a college education to succeed. Many people thrive in vocational fields like real estate, plumbing, or entrepreneurship. Someone who’s committed to continuous growth often outperforms a college graduate who lacks the drive.
- Mary Shenouda, the creator of *Paleochef*, is a prime example. She dropped out of college but built a thriving career as a performance chef by learning through real-world experience.
- Be like a sponge, soaking up knowledge from books, people, and life’s experiences.

 To learn, you need to be curious and humble: to truly listen, absorb and apply what you’ve learned.

- Successful people are often willing to share their wisdom with those who’re ready to ask good questions, listen and absorb. Arnold’s curiosity attracted many mentors and opportunities, allowing him to learn from influential figures like Joe Weider (bodybuilding), Lucille Ball (acting), and Milton Berle (business).
- Success comes from truly listening and applying what you learned. For example, Arnold initially wanted to play Kyle

KEY QUOTES

“The worst thing that can happen when you do the work to overcome adversity... is that you fail again and learn one more way that doesn’t work.... what do you have to lose?”

“You don’t know as much as you think you do, so shut your mouth and open your mind.”

“It’s only when you learn to soak up what those people tell you...that you truly begin to make yourself useful to others and become a resource yourself.”

“Important, interesting, powerful people are drawn to those who ask good questions and listen well...They want to help you.”

“Having the patience and humility to listen well is an essential ingredient of curiosity, and it’s the secret to learning.”

Reese in *The Terminator*, believing the hero role suited him better. However, after listening carefully to director James Cameron, he realized the Terminator character had far more potential. This decision not only boosted his career, but also taught him valuable lessons during the production process.

- Remember the use-it-or-lose it rule, and make sure you put the knowledge and skills into practice before they fade.



7. GIVING BACK: Break the Mirror and Serve Others



No one is truly "self-made", since every success is built upon someone else's ideas, efforts, and support. No one succeeds alone.

- While Arnold is often credited for his discipline and hard work, he recognizes that there are many people behind his success, including his parents, mentors like Joe Weider (who brought him to America), Steve Reeves and Reg Park (who inspired him in bodybuilding and movies), and John Milius (who cast him as Conan the Barbarian).
- Having benefited from others' contributions, each of us has a social responsibility to give back and help others. Arnold encourages us to "break the mirror"—stop focusing on ourselves and start focusing on others' needs. When you look beyond your own reflection and open yourself up to others, it also leads to deeper happiness, purpose, and growth.



Life isn't a zero-sum game. Giving doesn't reduce what you have—it benefits everyone involved and generates compounding effects.

- Real fulfillment doesn't come from personal achievements alone, but from uplifting others and serving your community.
 - Arnold first experienced this in the gym, where he and his fellow bodybuilders supported and pushed each other, leading to mutual improvement and advancing bodybuilding as a sport. Everyone wins in the process.
 - Similarly, the best actors are not the ones who focus only on themselves, but those who collaborate to make every scene better for everyone involved.

KEY QUOTES

"If you don't regularly flex your mind like a muscle and put your knowledge to work, it will eventually lose its power."

"We are all here thanks to the contributions of other people...recognize that you have a responsibility to give back. To help others. To send the ladder back down and lift the next group up. To pay it forward. To be useful."

"We can all grow together, get richer together, get stronger together. Everyone can win, in their own time, in their own way."

"Little things always have a tendency to become big things, and I am confident that one day something small will lead you to something big that you feel equipped to give back to in a bigger way."

- Giving back is not just a social responsibility or a way to support your goals. It also brings happiness, fulfillment, and connection.
 - When we help others, it triggers the release of hormones like oxytocin, endorphins, and vasopressin, which are associated with feelings of pleasure, love, and bonding. This creates the “helper’s high” which can be addictive, motivating you to give even more.
 - A Harvard study found that giving—no matter the amount—consistently *boosts happiness*.
- Arnold started his journey with a self-focused vision but gradually shifted towards a community-focused vision as he recognized the power and fulfillment of giving back.



Regardless of your situation, there are always ways to give back.

- Try doing an inventory of your skills and resources to determine what you can offer—whether it’s time, experience, assets like a car (to help with logistical support), or tools (to perform specific tasks).
- You can also give back through small acts of kindness, like helping someone with groceries, lending an ear, or offering advice. Every act creates a ripple effect, whether it impacts one person or thousands.
- Alternatively, think of what someone has done for you in the past, then pay it forward by doing the same for someone else.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

The tools and principles in this book go beyond achieving personal success; they offer a roadmap for finding purpose, fulfillment, and becoming valuable to those around you. Arnold challenges readers not only to pursue their goals but to continually ask, “How can I be useful?” The book also includes actionable steps, personal stories and insights to guide you toward becoming the best version of yourself—while making a meaningful impact on others. For more details, visit beusefulbook.com.

KEY QUOTES

“You can make someone’s day better and your own day better with the same act of kindness and generosity. And you don’t need to be rich or flush with cash to do it.”

“It’s not about the amount that you give, it’s about the fact that you give at all. It’s the act of giving that produces the increased happiness.”

“In our society that is so self-absorbed, begin to look less at yourself and more at each other.”

“We’re all in this thing called life together. It’s not a zero-sum game. It’s one that can have multiple winners.”